As he grew, friends remember a robust child who enjoyed football and athletics. He joined his pals on rambles and exploits into the countryside and could often be found rowing up and down the banks of the River Blies aboard a rickety homemade raft. A surviving photograph from the period shows his young face smiling brightly with other enthusiastic members of the Pioneer musical band, known as the Schallmeienkapelle. They had their own songs, and Erich could play just about every marching number on the drums and the entire repertoire of Communist tunes.

At Wiebelskirchen Protestant elementary school, a rather rambling edifice in a poor state of repair, he proved an indifferent pupil with a keen sense of humour. In fact, according to a fellow student, a curly-haired boy named Kurt Humbs, even when Honecker got a beating, he always laughed. ‘Erich just couldn’t cry,’ Humbs marvelled, saying his young friend gained the reputation as a bit of a joker.5

Lively accounts suggest there certainly was a lot of physical punishment; with masters amassing a collection of paddles, birch twigs, rulers and belts. ‘At school, we fought physical punishment,’ Honecker recorded in the pamphlet Vorbild des Pioniere. ‘When our singing teacher, a former army sergeant, was about to paddle one of us, the whole class would protest. The Pioneer paper, Die Trommel, gave a lot of help in this campaign’. He never forgot how that teacher, Herr Bock, kept his whipping cane in a violin case.

When he forgot to take along the violin case, which happened now and then, he sent pupils to fetch it. Once, when I was ordered to do so, I opened the case on the way, broke the cane, this instrument of submissiveness, and threw it into the River Blies. Of course, the teacher who beat us procured a new cane. However, a signal had been given, and our self-confidence increased. Later we put a newspaper on his desk. On the last page there was a column entitled ‘Bock, the Flogger’. Of course, we also had good teachers and wanted to learn.